

INFORM



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THE COURAGE TO CHANGE.



“Old tricks won’t open new doors.” With society facing political, social, environmental and technological challenges on a global level, this old adage is as relevant as ever for our times. We also face challenges in the daily business of serving our customers – economic pressure, short deadlines, unpredictable orders. At the same time, we benefit from the stability of being located in Switzerland.

Nevertheless, we must always be on the lookout for new solutions. We strongly believe that real innovation can only be achieved by thinking out of the box and seeing change as something to be embraced, not feared. The customers and partners featured in this edition are prime examples of this innovative spirit. All three companies have had to make critical decisions and embrace ongoing change over the course of their history. Their success today proves that having the courage to change pays off.

There is also a lot of action here at Otto Hofstetter AG. In these pages you can find the first results of the Otto Hofstetter S-Line, a range of semi-standardised tools for the packaging industry. The production time for these tools is considerably shorter, the total cost of ownership significantly lower, and the environmental footprint notably smaller. We have also made significant progress in developing PET preform tools for side entry systems, and we are going full speed ahead with new initiatives for our customer service and development support. We will tell you more once the results reach our high-quality standards.

In the meantime, I wish you continued success with your business and hope you enjoy this issue of our customer magazine.

Yours Otto Hofstetter



Title page.

Aslan Tekin, production manager, and Axel Autermann, CEO and owner of PLAMA Plastik-Maschinen GmbH, rely on the sustainability of the moulds of Otto Hofstetter AG for the production of their PET preforms.

Imprint.

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PET GROWS.

PLAMA Plastik-Maschinen GmbH in Haan, located 20 kilometres to the east of Düsseldorf, Germany, has been producing high-quality PET preforms since 2009. In an interview with *inform*, CEO and owner **Axel Autermann** explains the history and plans of his up-and-coming company, his philosophy and why he believes that **proximity and durability** remain very important features of a production system even in today's networked and transient world.

When PLAMA was founded in 1977, PET preforms were still an area that had hardly been addressed by anyone.

What did the company's offering comprise initially?

PLAMA focused on the distribution of used machinery. At the beginning, the offer comprised injection moulding machines, with our focus later moving towards extrusion and blow moulding machines. Our speciality was and remains projects that require durability, expertise and service provision. Today, around 70 per cent of our sales are accounted for by extrusion machines, primarily on a second-hand basis, although we also sell new systems. The area is now independent and operates under the brand "PLAMA Engineering" (www.plama.de).

PLAMA was founded by H. Thom and K.-H. Pütter. You are now owner and CEO. How did this come about?

I joined PLAMA in 1985 when I started my training as a wholesale and export merchant. At the end of the 1980s, K.-H. Pütter left the company, providing me with the opportunity to contribute to the firm. From this time, H. Thom and I assumed the roles of senior and junior, respectively. I became a co-owner in 1996, and the company was subsequently managed jointly. Since the retirement of my business partner at the end of 2003, I have held all shares in the company and preside over both PLAMA Plastik-Maschinen GmbH and the subsidiary PLAMA Engineering GmbH as CEO.

In 2004, PLAMA moved into the area of PET bottle production with the takeover of a company. What prompted you to make this move?

There was absolutely an element of chance in this development. One of our blow moulding machine customers was experiencing financial difficulties. The customer portfolio was in place and the systems were in good order. It was only at a business level that there were shortcomings. We took the decision that the company would join us and continue its production operations. As it has turned out, it was a good decision for everybody involved. As early as 2007, we were producing bottles with three systems.

You have also been producing PET preforms since 2009. Why?

Our bottle production volume was increasing year on year. As far back as 2007, we were considering whether it would not make sense to manufacture the required preforms ourselves. We also recognised that the blow moulding business only has a limited future over the long term due to the high transport volume. In 2009, operations started with the first system, and during the following 18 months we only produced for our

own requirements. We used this time intensively in order to achieve a level of quality that corresponds to our philosophy and to acquire the required certificates.

What does production look like today?

Since recently, we have been producing with several high-performance systems. At present, we could theoretically achieve a production volume of almost 800 million preforms and 150 million bottles. I say theoretically because you, of course, also have to sell the volume you produce. In reality, we anticipate that we will produce between 600 and 650 million preforms and process between 8000 and 10,000 tonnes of material this year.

"PLAMA IS POSTING GROWTH OF BETWEEN 25 AND 30 PER CENT EVERY YEAR. PREFORMS ARE OUR FUTURE."

Axel Autermann, CEO and owner

What does the future hold?

We now manufacture preforms from start to finish and deliver them to our customers using our own vehicles. PLAMA is posting growth of between 25 and 30 per cent every year. Preforms are our future. We are therefore planning a further PET preform system. According to our planning figures, we are likely to achieve a capacity of well over 1 billion in 2019 or 2020.

That is an impressive growth trajectory. What do you view as the benefits of PLAMA?

With us, customers are treated as equals and feel that their concerns are taken seriously. My many years of experience have shown that customers very much enjoy collaborating with smaller companies where they are really understood and viewed as a partner. The second point is our flexibility, and this goes hand in hand with the foregoing. Even during this exceptional summer, it was therefore possible to deliver to our customers within two or three days after the receipt of their orders. I believe a further benefit is the consistency we provide in terms of quality. An order is always completed on a single machine and with a single raw material. This means that the first preform is identical to the two-millionth. A fact that is decisive in the blow moulding and filling process. Our customers also benefit from our experience that we have in the blow moulding of bottles.

You have made considerable investments in recent years and are planning to take a further growth step. At the

same time, PET is coming under public pressure. How do you view the future of the raw material?

The debate is difficult. In principle, the raw material offers many benefits and is very diverse as regards recycling. It is important that both producers and consumers accept their responsibility with respect to the environment. Our membership of PETCYCLE is one of various measures that we at PLAMA have taken with this in mind.

What is PETCYCLE exactly?

PETCYCLE is an association that was founded by committed companies in Germany. Its members comprise firms that are active in the plastic container value chain. As producers, we are required to ensure that recycle makes up at least 55 per cent of our products. This material is acquired from used PET bottles of participating beverage manufacturers. PETCYCLE bottles can be identified on the basis of an octagonal or decagonal neck ring. The symbol for a “clean” bottle.

Where do you see diversification potential for PLAMA?

PLAMA continuously receives requests to produce other products. For environmental reasons, as well as others, we want to remain a regional company, however. We tend to envisage expansion in the area in which we are already ac-

tive. At present, the level of demand in the region exceeds the volume that we can supply. And for as long as this is the case, we will continue to invest in our current core business.

Since 2014, you have been putting your faith in the Swiss configuration Otto Hofstetter-Netstal. What prompted you to make this move?

Quality, durability and proximity were the most important criteria in the selection. We were ultimately left with two options and chose the combination of Otto Hofstetter and Netstal. I was further convinced by a factory visit in Switzerland. Everything was disclosed and the origin of every part was traceable. It is very important to me that I know where my infrastructure comes from.

Why are proximity and durability important to you?

It is important to me to be able to respond to any challenge. After all, if we are unable to deliver once, customers will look elsewhere. It is for this reason that I want to have partners that are located close by and to be sure that they can respond quickly. Durability refers to the mould in two respects. Firstly, the moulds are extremely robust and allow for very long running times without interruption. Where necessary, we are therefore able to leave a machine running non-stop

“EVEN THIS SUMMER, IT WAS POSSIBLE FOR US TO DELIVER TO OUR CUSTOMERS WITHIN TWO OR THREE DAYS.”

Axel Autermann,
CEO and owner



"QUALITY, DURABILITY
AND PROXIMITY WERE IMPORTANT
CRITERIA IN THE SELECTION
OF THE SYSTEM."

Axel Autermann,
CEO and owner

for four or five months. Secondly, the master mould of Otto Hofstetter AG allows for the mould to be adjusted in line with changing requirements. If I were to establish my company today, I would once more place my faith in this combination.

In which areas could the production of PET preforms be optimised?

Alongside material costs, energy costs are a massive issue for us in Germany. This is also the reason why we do not work with used systems. While this would of course be possible, the energy balance would be considerably less favourable. The new Otto Hofstetter AG system consumes around 30 per cent less power but provides almost 55 per cent greater capacity. Due to the power situation in Germany, we are looking at switching to gas burners.

In which areas could Otto Hofstetter AG support you?

With respect to energy costs, the cooling time is currently an issue. A development has taken place at Otto Hofstetter AG. The cooling times are already at a good level. Nevertheless, we would of course be very happy about any further improvement in the moulds' energy balance.

In what area could Otto Hofstetter AG still improve?

It would be desirable if Otto Hofstetter AG implemented new findings as quickly as possible in new products. I also see potential for improvements in the area of product development and with respect to testing possibilities. Prototypes are a very important matter for us as well. Here, time and costs

are decisive factors. I would very much welcome improvements in this area. After all, it also represents an opportunity for new business for Otto Hofstetter AG.

Customisation is a megatrend that is challenging many areas of the economy. Are you observing corresponding signs in the PET world?

At PLAMA, we are not fans of custom products. The risks are too great, both for our customers and for ourselves. In the case of standardised products, we can assume that they will also function during heatwaves in summer or very cold periods in winter. If we are not absolutely convinced that an order can be implemented seamlessly, we do not accept it. In general, we believe that standards represent the safest path for both partners.

Thank you very much for the enlightening interview, and I wish you continued success at PLAMA in the future.



PLAMA Plastik-Maschinen GmbH

Bergische Strasse 15, 42781 Haan, Germany

Founded in 1977

Member of PETCYCLE

Specialised in the production of high-quality PET preforms and bottles for mineral water and soft drinks. Own logistics team and own vehicle fleet

www.plama-pet.de

A WHOLE NEW PACKAGE.



The introduction of the new **Otto Hofstetter S-Line** is putting a **totally new range of moulds** for the packaging industry on the market. The main advantages of the new S-Line are **shorter run times for projects, lower costs** and a master mould that is **reusable**. When it comes to quality, this new mould series lives up to the high standards that customers have come to expect from Otto Hofstetter AG: **Swiss precision and reliability**.

One important trait of Swiss companies is that they always adapt to the current needs of their customers. This is made possible by close customer contact and keeping the lines of communication open – a partnership that fosters the sharing of important feedback. Companies then use this feedback to optimise what they offer or to find new solutions to old problems, keeping in step with customers' needs and the market.

Challenges in the packaging industry.

Packaging companies want to offer precision, customisation and durability. However, they face increasing cost and time pressure and ever-shorter product lifespans, which makes it difficult to find economic production solutions. Costs have to be cut, of course, but at what price? Customers will not accept companies that start cutting corners when it comes to quality, and having less reliable production puts delivery dates at risk. What's a modern packaging company to do?

The new Otto Hofstetter S-Line.

Over the past several months, the engineering team at Otto Hofstetter AG developed a solution to this dilemma. The Otto Hofstetter S-Line represents a totally new generation of injection moulds for plastic packaging that can cut project times – from the time the customer orders the mould to when it is delivered – in half. Prices for new PAC moulds from the new Otto Hofstetter S-Line are well below those of competitors. With these advantages, customers can enjoy shorter amortisation periods and lower life cycle costs. Certain components from the new mould line can also be reused, which reduces both the ecological footprint and the cost of injection moulds.

From a proud tradition.

Don't worry – our new moulds still have the same product DNA as their predecessors. Various premium Swiss brands have already shown us that it is possible to adapt while staying true to your core strengths and values. Take, for example, the famous Swiss army knife by Victorinox or the much coveted watches from IWC Schaffhausen. If a potential customer decides to go ahead with a purchase, the product will not be completely redeveloped. As long as the customer can adapt their needs to what is on offer, it is available immediately. And even when small individual details need to be adapted, these masterfully crafted products can be delivered in a reasonable time frame. This is made possible by standardised components and processes, but the core product remains the same: it is still an IWC watch or Victorinox Swiss army knife.

**THE INTRODUCTION OF THE
NEW OTTO HOFSTETTER S-LINE
IS PUTTING A TOTALLY NEW
GENERATION OF PACKAGING MOULDS
ON THE MARKET.**

Semi-standardised, full quality.

Even though injection moulds used for packaging are always customised, they are to a large extent very similar. A margarine tub for Brand A is not fundamentally different from that of Brand B, and a cup for Airline A is more or less the same as a cup for Airline B – and so on. With this in mind, the engineering team at Otto Hofstetter AG developed standards that can be used as base models for similar products. Packaging can be individualised within a predetermined framework: length, width, height, diameter and number of cavities. The design

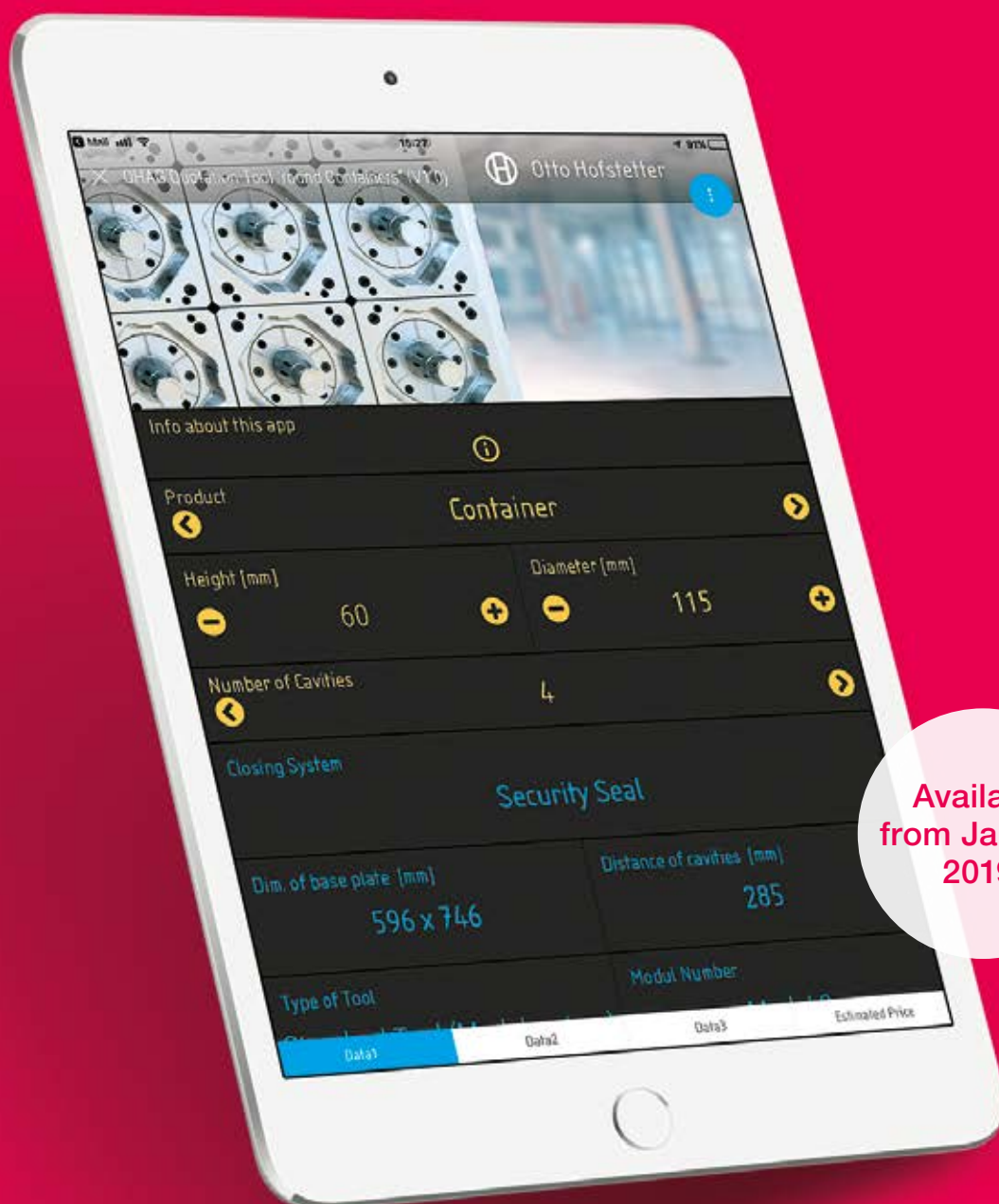
process for this kind of semi-standardised mould takes only half as long as for a completely custom mould made from scratch.

**THE OTTO HOFSTETTER S-LINE
TAKES HALF AS LONG TO
DESIGN WHILE RETAINING 100%
OF ITS QUALITY.**

Everything about setting up a mould from the Otto Hofstetter S-Line remains the same as with a custom mould: the same steel quality, the same team of specialists and the same processes for quality assurance. Just as with our other products, each PAC mould from the new Otto Hofstetter S-Line is tested under production conditions in our tech centre and only delivered when the prototypes have been developed to the full satisfaction of the customer. Our top-notch after-sales service is also no different.

Calculated with just the click of a mouse.

Because the new mould line is semi-standardised, we can offer our customers yet another innovation. Interested companies can access our unique mould configurator free of charge at www.otto-hofstetter.swiss/s-line. With just a few clicks, you can set the type of mould, the type of packaging, the dimensions and the number of cavities. The configurator automatically produces a price estimate based on the specifications. This means that for the first time, packaging producers can now calculate the necessary outlay at a very early phase of the project.



Available
from January
2019.

New: online configurator for packaging moulds.

Interested companies can access our unique configurator free of charge at www.otto-hofstetter.swiss/s-line. With just a few clicks, you can set the type of mould, the type of packaging, the dimensions and the number of cavities. The configurator then automatically produces a price estimate.

UPHOLDING VALUES.

ITC Packaging is headquartered in Ibi, Spain, approximately 40 kilometres north of Alicante, and has around 250 employees. The **family-owned company's** willingness to grow and evolve has made it what it is today: one of the top three plastic packaging producers in Spain. *inform* spoke with **Evelio García, Technical Office Manager** at ITC Packaging, about the company's impressive history.

Representing ITC Packaging at the headquarters in Ibi, Spain in an interview with *inform*: Evelio García, Technical Office Manager, Betry Valls Gras, Head Public Relations, and José Luis Olmedo, Managing Director.

Which were the ITC origins? What did the company look like back then?

Carlos Valls founded Minison S.A. in 1971. The company specialised in the development and production of accessories for toys, such as voice chips and similar components. At this time, Ibi was the heart of the Spanish toy industry, and many companies here were involved in this field in one way or another.

In 1991, ITC Packaging was founded. What was the reason for this change?

At the end of the 1980s, we began to experience the first signs of the decline of the local toy industry. Companies in the area began to feel the impact of imported toys from low-wage countries and the growing popularity of video games. This was the reason why, under the direction of Rafael Valls, the son of the founder, the company began to diversify and started producing extruded cables, for which a new company was created, ITC. We are currently in the third generation of the company with Betry Valls, ITC Head Public Relations and member of the Council.

When did ITC start producing packaging?

The Universal Exhibition of Seville took place in 1992. The mascot of the fair was named Curro. It was a large white bird with elephant legs, as well as a long, rainbow-coloured beak and a rainbow crest. Curro was to be printed on the packaging for the ice cream at the Expo. Taking advantage of our great expertise in the toy industry, we were able to develop a food container but with toy look and functionality. This was the first of an extensive series of such packaging, which today is one of our strengths.

**"WHEN A NEW TREND EMERGES,
WE CAN OFFER CUSTOMERS SUITABLE
OFFERS VERY EARLY ON."**

Evelio García, Technical Office Manager

Tell me more about ITC today.

We currently have two locations and around 250 employees. We operate two plants here in Ibi and one in Sopela, near Bilbao. Here in Ibi we produce polypropylene packaging and PET containers. Our plant in Sopela, which we acquired from the Coveris Group in mid-2014, also operates an injection moulding system. In the last year, we have sold more than 1.3 billion packages on five continents. Packaging for food and beverages, sweets and chocolates, baby nutrition and

formula, and dairy products comprise 80 per cent of our production; the remaining 20 per cent is made up of containers for cleaning products, paints and other products.

How is ITC positioned on the market?

Thanks to the dedication of our employees day in and day out, we have become one of the largest producers of thin-walled packaging with IML technology on the Spanish market. In the area of ice cream packaging, we have a leading position in Spain and Europe.



What are ITC Packaging's specialities?

We are not specialised in one specific area or industry. Our core business is called MyPack and allows us to bespoke product packaging. For these kinds of projects, we evaluate our customers' needs and then develop a suitable solution. Thanks to our extensive expertise, we are able to complete these kinds of resource-intensive projects in just a short time.

What is the reason for ITC's success in the area of ice cream packaging?

Our region has a long history with frozen food products. For this reason, we have focused our efforts in this area accordingly, and gained a great deal of valuable experience in terms of handling frozen foods. Thanks to our expertise in this area, we are always up to date on the latest developments. When a new trend emerges, we can offer customers suitable offers very early on. Naturally, we also benefit from our speed and flexibility.



First-class equipment and highly motivated employees have made ITC Packaging one of the three largest thin-wall packaging manufacturers in Spain.



ITC also produces packaging for baby nutrition and formula – an industry with a great deal of regulations and requirements. Which aspects of this industry require particular attention?

Our expertise in this delicate area has motivated us to improve our processes and continually optimise our production systems. Moreover, we closely adhere to the global standards for food safety and have been BRC-certified since 2006. When it comes to producing packaging, we pay close attention to the properties of the product at hand and its production conditions.

"PACKAGING IS MORE THAN JUST AN OBJECT OR AN ORDINARY CONTAINER. IT'S AN EXPERIENCE FOR THE CUSTOMER."

José Luis Olmedo, ITC Managing Director

ITC counts a number of well-known brands as customers. Why do these companies rely on you?

We have a customer centric orientation due to our service and flexibility. We also have a constant and dynamic commitment to innovation, values appreciated and recognized by our customers that make up our DNA as a business. Our customers appreciate our company philosophy and our dedication. With ITC, they work with a team that has a great deal of in-depth specialist knowledge and expertise and puts their heart and soul into every project. The modern infrastructure and trained staff at our plants guarantee our customers top quality and absolute reliability in terms of deadlines.

Lids with integrated scoops, coffee capsules with integrated barriers, in-mould labelling: ITC keeps attracting a lot of attention with innovative products and solutions. Why is that?

A passion for innovation is in our DNA. This dedication has allowed ITC to evolve from a manufacturer of toy accessories to a producer of extruded cables all the way to one of the top packaging producers in Europe. Our Research and Development department works every day to determine which direction the market is moving in and what kinds of containers will be needed to meet the requirements of the future. We invest 10 per cent of our turnover annually into research and development, and introduce more than 20 new products every year.

You mentioned that ITC is very fast when it comes to completing projects. How do you achieve this level of efficiency?

One reason for our efficiency is our many years of experience with complex projects. Starting with the Curro ice cream packaging for Expo '92, we have been repeatedly tasked with bringing original ideas to life. Over time, we have developed our own processes that we use today in order to realise these kinds of complex solutions within a reasonable time frame while offering customers attractive conditions. A second reason is how quickly we react and answer customer questions. At ITC, the whole team is fully involved in our R&D projects. This ensures that no information is lost and that there are no misunderstandings when it comes to customer requirements.

Your company motto is “Trust your senses”. What does packaging need in order to live up to this slogan?

This sentence perfectly sums up our approach. As José Luis Olmedo, ITC Managing Director, usually says, “Packaging is more than just an object or an ordinary container. It’s an experience for the customer.” It conveys brand values and information, while also elevating a product and setting it apart from the competition. Packaging is only successful when it triggers positive associations in the consumer, which are then transferred to the product itself.

What are the latest trends in the world of consumer goods packaging?

It is an exciting time in the industry. The general changes that have taken place over the past few years in society are increasingly influencing packaging as well. Ready-to-go or ready-to-drink products, health foods, and the increasingly variable portion sizes are just a few examples. All of these changes require new packaging concepts.

Where do you see the greatest potential for reducing packaging’s environmental impact?

At ITC, we have been working on decreasing the weight and wall thickness of our products for years. Furthermore, we continually optimise our production processes so that we can lower our energy consumption and reduce transport distances. We are currently working on a number of projects in close cooperation with a variety of institutions and research centres. We are looking for new materials and ways to make our packaging more recyclable, and also trying to find new features that will increase the shelf life of food and beverages in order to reduce food waste.

We have recently become a founding member of AVI, the Valencia Agency for Innovation, with Betry Valls, ITC Head Public Relations, as Agency Counselor. This organisation aims to actively promote innovations that increase sustainability in order to generate momentum for the necessary paradigm shift.

You have been working with Otto Hofstetter AG tools since 2013. What was the main reason for this step?

We first got in touch with the company when we were faced with the challenge of producing a lid with an integrated scoop. We weren’t just looking for a mould manufacturer that could offer us precision; we envisioned a partner that was specialised in the development of new technical processes and was willing to share their expertise and knowledge with us.

And did Otto Hofstetter AG meet these expectations?

The service we received completely exceeded our expectations. Otto Hofstetter understood exactly what we needed and worked together with us to develop a solution that would satisfy even the strictest of requirements in terms of functionality and precision. The lid with the integrated scoop was a big hit on the market. It has even been introduced in South Korea.

Where do you see room for improvement on the part of Otto Hofstetter AG?

There are two aspects that our customers have also asked us to improve upon. The first would be a shorter design time for the injection moulds. We receive a great deal of quick turn-over projects. Because these projects are generally seasonal or in line with a current trend, the time to market is extremely important. The second aspect would be the mould price. The price itself is not too high per se, but when you combine it with the type, complexity and operating time of the product, this changes the proportion. A certain amount of flexibility in this area would make things much easier.

Thank you for this interesting discussion. On behalf of all *inform* readers, we wish you all the best for the future.



ITC Packaging

Headquarters: Pol. Ind. Retiro Casa Nova, Calle Valladolid, 8
03440 Ibi (Alicante), Spain

Founded in 1991

Empolyees: approx. 250

Two production plants in Ibi, one production plant in Sopela (Bilbao)
Packaging for paints, cosmetics, pre-cooked foods, ice-cream,
sauces and cookery, sweets and chocolates.

SIX TO ONE.

Textiles made from recycled PET have been available for some time, but public awareness remains low. The Swiss national ice hockey team wanted to help change that, so they traded in their traditional red jerseys for green ones – showing a commitment to innovation that is characteristic of Switzerland.

When you think of Swiss athletes competing at European or world championship games or the Olympics, one colour comes to mind: red. But that was not the case for the Swiss national ice hockey team at a recent tournament: their jerseys were green.

Tradition of sustainability.

An unusual look for a Swiss sports team, to be sure – but a great way to raise awareness about the potential of using recycled PET to produce textiles for athletic gear. Most people are not aware that sportswear manufacturers offer products made of recycled bottles, even though these products have already been on the market for a while.

**TWO-THIRDS OF
SWITZERLAND'S ENERGY
NEEDS ARE COVERED
BY SUSTAINABLE SOURCES.**

Recycling world champions.

The players on the national ice hockey team are not the only ones in Switzerland who are committed to reducing their environmental impact. Sustainability is a Swiss characteris-





tic. Two-thirds of the country's energy needs, for example, are covered by sustainable sources – the most important being hydroelectric power, which accounts for 59 per cent of energy production. The Swiss are also diligent recyclers: 96 per cent of glass, 90 per cent of aluminium, 81 per cent of paper and 82 per cent of PET bottles are collected and remain in circulation.

Open to innovation.

Strict emissions requirements for vehicles and the popularity of e-bikes show just how serious the Swiss are when it comes to sustainability. This is also true of their attitude toward innovation, whether it is making use of new technologies or developing them themselves. This is reflected in the number of patents registered in the country: 7283 in 2017, which is equivalent to 884 patents per million of inhabitants. An impressive figure that has earned Switzerland the distinction of being the world champion of patents. The driving force behind all this innovation is generated by private businesses, which contribute over two-thirds of the total investments in research and development.

SWITZERLAND WAS THE PATENT WORLD CHAMPION IN 2017, WITH 884 PATENTS PER MILLION INHABITANTS.

Switzerland: a winning team.

Actively implementing traditional Swiss values creates a competitive advantage on the global business stage. The World Economic Forum's Global Competitiveness Report has put Switzerland at the top of its list for the past nine years in a row – an achievement made possible by the country's macroeconomic environment, well-functioning labour market and willingness to adapt new technologies.

Green jersey wins.

In addition to being eco-friendly role models, the national ice hockey team also embodies the typically Swiss values of precision and reliability. Thanks to their accuracy and endurance, the green jersey-clad team won the one-hour game with a six-to-one victory.

LESS TALK, MORE ACTION.



Bohrbüchsen AG, located in Heimberg near Thun, has been one of Otto Hofstetter AG's production partners for decades. The company **employs around 30 people** and since its founding has been a specialised producer of **cylindrical components** made of different metals. *inform* met up with company directors and owners **Werner Keller** and **Hans Jörg Glauser**.

Hans Jörg Glauser (left) and Werner Keller have been managing Bohrbüchsen AG since 1992. The company has been one of Otto Hofstetter AG's partners since 2003.



In the heart of picturesque Switzerland.

Visitors to Bohrbüchsen AG who are coming from cities or from abroad have a scenic treat in store: the area where the company is headquartered looks like a typical postcard of Switzerland. The popular tourist destination Interlaken, the fascinating Giessbach Falls and the breathtaking Jungfrauoch are all located nearby. Jungfrauoch, a mountain destination also known as the Top of Europe, attracts over one million visitors per year.

Classic Switzerland.

Bohrbüchsen AG fits well nestled among these Swiss tourism highlights – it is just as representative of Switzerland as those picture-perfect destinations. The Heimberg-based precision engineering company has the characteristics of a typical Swiss SME: highly specialised, highly dependable, and powered by committed, loyal employees – not to mention consistently focused on working more precisely, designing more effective technical solutions and serving their customers better.

**“AS A FAMILY-OWNED COMPANY,
OTTO HOFSTETTER AG
SHARES OUR LONG-TERM THINKING.
THIS IS WHY WE CAN DEPEND
ON EACH OTHER.”**

Werner Keller, owner and director

In the thick of it from day one.

Successful SMEs in Switzerland very often have similar management structures. They usually consist of a member of the founding family with the right field-specific knowledge as well as an employee with subject matter expertise who has grown with the company and received a financial stake in it. This also holds true for Bohrbüchsen AG. Werner Keller and Hans Jörg Glauser manage the company. “My grandfather and my father were the founders,” explains Keller. “Hans Jörg started his apprenticeship with us in 1968 and, except for a short break, he has been with us ever since.” Both men love the smell of metal and oil and are in the workshop every day, supporting the production process. Not that this comes as a surprise – their office is even somewhat integrated into the shop floor.

Sharing common values.

Less talk, more action – that’s the motto of Hans Jörg Glauser and Werner Keller. More than just being action-oriented, they also want to be reliable long-term business partners. “We’re

interested in customers who will work with us over the long term, not those who just want a component here or there and then disappear again," says Glauser. This philosophy is something the company has in common with Otto Hofstetter AG. "Otto Hofstetter AG is also a family-owned business that thinks in the long term, so we can depend on each other." For both companies, it is not simply about trying to squeeze out as much profit as possible – unlike in some large corporations. According to Glauser, these shared values are the reason why Bohrbüchsen AG and Otto Hofstetter AG have such a successful long-term partnership.

The name says it all.

Of course, Bohrbüchsen AG existed long before the partnership with Otto Hofstetter AG got under way in 2003. Jakob Keller and his father put the company in the commercial register of the canton of Bern on 14 September 1956. Since the focus from the beginning was to be on producing and selling drill bushings, they went ahead and named the company Bohrbüchsen – the German word for these components.

Drill bushings were just the beginning.

Over time, advancements in production and machine tool

technology led to a decrease in demand for drill bushings. "Thanks to our expertise in working with a wide variety of metals to a high degree of precision, our diversified machinery and our talented specialist staff, we were able to move into manufacturing other components." Looking back, Glauser notes that it was the company's expertise in manufacturing cylindrical components that brought in new orders. Today, drill bushings account for around six per cent of business. "We should actually shut down this business segment," says Keller critically. But interestingly, demand for drill bushings always increases when the economy is not running smoothly. Small amounts can also still be taken from the warehouse.

"THE SUCCESS OF OTTO HOFSTETTER AG SOMETIMES PUSHES US TO THE LIMITS OF OUR CAPACITY."

Hans Jörg Glauser, owner and director

Direct relationships are more efficient.

Otto Hofstetter AG has been making use of the specialist knowledge of their production partner in Heimberg for many years. Before the two companies began working together directly, Otto Hofstetter AG purchased standard components, such as Bohrbüchsen-produced nozzle holders, from a retailer. But with demand and special requirements mounting, around 15 years ago, the decision was made to work together directly. "Since Otto Hofstetter AG was already familiar with our products and our quality, and since both of our companies have fast decision-making processes, we came to an agreement very quickly," recalls Glauser.

Outside of the norm.

"In addition to nozzle holders, today we also produce parts for two-component moulds and many other special parts. In our business, the focus is increasingly on customised pieces that we have to develop. We receive the sketches and then get to work." According to Keller, Bohrbüchsen AG rarely has requests for standard components. "We used to always be able to keep some standard components in stock, but that's no longer possible today. We have to keep up the same level of precision while being even faster and more flexible."

Continuous learning for a strong partnership.

Although Heimberg and Uznach – the locations of Bohrbüchsen AG and Otto Hofstetter AG, respectively – are separated



The components for Otto Hofstetter AG have a tolerance of around 0.005 millimetres.



Bohrbüchsen AG is able to deliver this kind of quality thanks to their craftsmanship, experience and passion.

by 200 kilometres and a few mountains, the two companies have been able to develop a close, uncomplicated working relationship. “Otto Hofstetter AG sends us a drawing, we make an offer and then production already begins.” According to Keller, there are not a lot of follow-up questions. “Mechanics aren’t really mould manufacturers. But if you tell us what we have to pay attention to, then there won’t be any problems. We’ve learned a lot about injection moulds over the years that we’ve worked together so closely. Sometimes, we even have our own ideas about how a component or a process can be optimised. As long as we can deliver the required level of precision, Otto Hofstetter AG is always open to our input.”

Solutions in the spotlight.

Otto Hofstetter AG knows that they have a reliable partner in Heimberg. “Our relationship with Bohrbüchsen AG is of strategic importance. When you have tolerances of around 0.005 millimetres, it’s important to know that we can always and unconditionally depend on the specialists in Heimberg.” For Stefan Zatti, Head of Sales and Marketing at Otto Hofstetter AG, it is also important and expected for Bohrbüchsen AG to provide input when it comes to optimising existing mould components. A relationship of mutual appreciation is therefore crucial. And since both companies share a solution-oriented approach, if problems do pop up, the focus is on finding answers, not assigning blame.

Ensuring continuity.

“The success of Otto Hofstetter AG also helps us to be suc-

cessful. But it also pushes us to the limits of our capacity.” Glauser sees another challenge lying ahead: increasingly short delivery times combined with high levels of customisation. The solution will probably emerge from the company’s successful long-standing cooperation with three specialised partners who are also among the numerous small and medium-sized businesses in Switzerland that concentrate on a niche sector. These Swiss SMEs continually improve their expertise over time and pass it on to new generations of motivated young professionals – just like Bohrbüchsen AG and Otto Hofstetter AG. “As long as we can guarantee continuity when it comes to precision, leadership and reliability, we will continue working together with Otto Hofstetter AG to deliver the Swiss quality that our customers have come to expect,” remarks Keller.



Bohrbüchsen AG

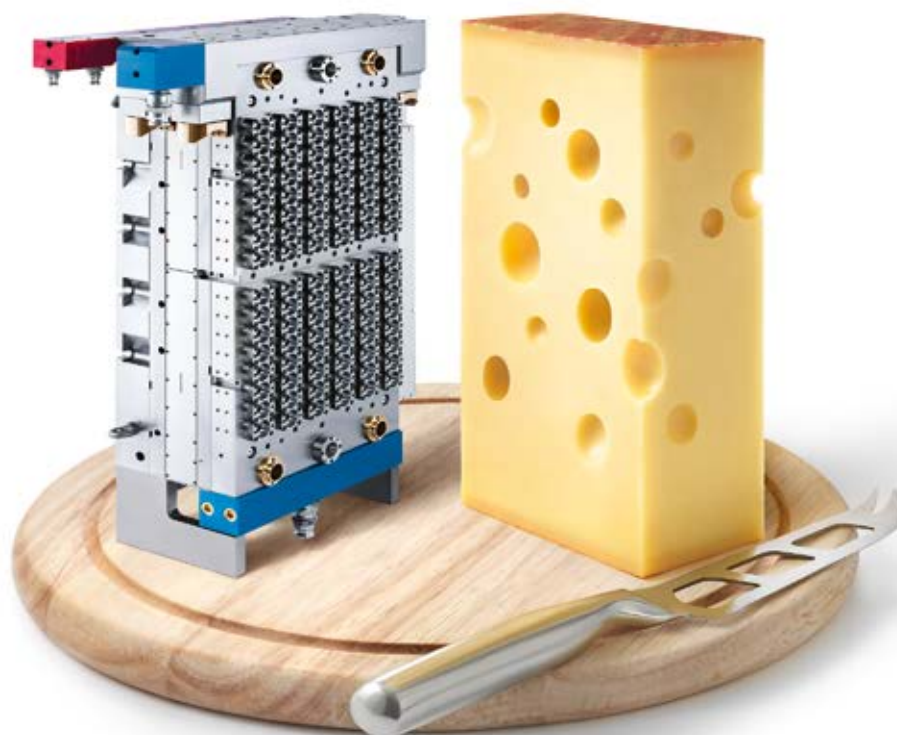
Schulgässli 34, 3627 Heimberg

Phone: +41 (0)33 437 11 48

E-Mail: info@bohrbuechsen.ch

www.bohrbuechsen.ch

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